

What does this mean? A government and/or a creditor can confiscate a business composed of land, machinery, coal pits, buildings, and so on. It can't confiscate your intellect. What do professionals sell? Not coal, not paint, not even pizza. What they sell most of all is their intellect.

Physicians, for example, can take their intellect anywhere in America. Their resources are quite portable. The same is true for dentists, attorneys, accountants, engineers, architects, veterinarians, and chiropractors. These are the occupations held by a disproportionate number of the sons and daughters of affluent couples throughout America.

What about the income characteristics of professionals as compared with the Johnson Coal Mining operation? Only a minority of self-employed professionals have ever made as much as \$600,000 profit in a single year. And most self-employed professionals spend many years in training, which is costly both in dollars and time. Nevertheless, most affluent parents believe that the lifetime benefits associated with being a professional greatly outweigh the costs. Remember, most of these parents pay all or a significant portion of their sons' and daughters' tuition and fees for training. Their vote is with their hard-earned money.

How will you vote? Notice that coal mining, on average, produced a higher net income (\$196,600) than any of the sole proprietorships listed in [Table 8-2](#). But what proportion of coal mining operations made any net income during the same period of time? Only about one in three (34.2 percent). This is in sharp contrast with the percentages of profitable businesses in each of the professional service categories listed in [Table 8-2](#). What percentages were profitable? About 87.2 percent of the offices of physicians, 94.9 percent of the offices of dentists, 92.5 percent of the offices of veterinarians, and 86.6 percent of the offices providing legal services.

Also examine the average return on receipts. On average, it would take \$2.4 million in receipts for a coal mining operation on average to generate a net income of \$196,600 (approximately 8.2 percent of \$2.4 million in receipts). What about physicians? The average net income of a physician's office is \$87,000—that's 56.2 percent of the \$154,804 receipts generated. With that kind of return on receipts, how many dollars in receipts would a physician's office have to generate to earn the same average net income that coal mining businesses earned (\$196,600)? Only \$349,800, a far cry from the \$2.4 million required of coal mining operations. The figure's even lower for osteopathic physicians; on average, they require receipts of \$340,138 to earn the expected \$196,600